A Coney Island of the Mind

By Lawrence Ferlinghetti

INTRODUCTION

By immersing ourselves in poetry we realize how the greatest poets not only change the way we see the world but also cause us to question our perception and interpretation of everyday reality. We realize that the greatest poetry "subverts the dominant paradigm," ultimately challenges the status quo of the world, and transforms it into something new and strange. Come with me to Lawrence Ferlinghetti's Coney Island of the Mind in the decade after the end of World War II . . . the war to end all wars . . .

In Goya's greatest scenes we seem to see
the people of the world
exactly at the moment when
they first attained the title of
"suffering humanity"
They write upon the page
in a veritable rage
of adversity
Heaped up
groaning with babies and bayonets

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under cement skies
in an abstract landscape of blasted trees
bent statues bats wings and beaks
slippery gibbets
cadavers and carnivorous cocks
and all the final hollering monsters
of the
"imagination of disaster"
they are so bloody real
it is as if they really still existed
And they do
Only the landscape is changed
They are still ranged along the roads
plagued by legionaries
false windmills and demented roosters
They are the same people
only further from home
on freeways fifty lanes wide
on a concrete continent
spaced with bland billboards
illustrating imbecile illusions of happiness

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The scene shows fewer tumbrils
but more maimed citizens
in painted cars
and they have strange license plates
and engines
that devour America

Oh, Beautiful for spacious skies; for amber waves of grain . . . purple mountains . . . fruited plains; America the beautiful?

The poet's eye obscenely seeing
sees the surface of the round world
with its drunk rooftops
and wooden oiseaux on clotheslines
and its clay males and females
with hot legs and rosebud breasts
in rollaway beds
and its trees full of mysteries
and its Sunday parks and speechless statues
and its America

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with its ghost towns and empty Ellis Islands
and its surrealist landscape of
mindless prairies
supermarket suburbs
steamheated cemeteries
cinerama holy days
and protesting cathedrals
a kissproof world of plastic toiletseats tampax and taxis
drugged store cowboys and Las Vegas virgins
disowned Indians and cinemad matrons
unroman senators and conscientious non-objectors
and all the other fatal shorn-up fragments
of the immigrant's dream come too true
and mislaid
among the sunbathers

America, America, God shed his grace on thee; and crowned they good with brotherhood. Brotherhood? What brotherhood?

In a surrealist year
of sandwichmen and sunbathers

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dead sunflowers and live telephones
house-broken politicos with party whips
performed as usual
in the rings of their sawdust circuses
where tumblers and human cannonballs
filled the air like cries
when some cool clown
pressed an inedible mushroom button
and an inaudible Sunday bomb
fell down
catching the president at his prayers
on the 19th green

O it was a spring
of fur leaves and cobalt flowers
when the cadillacs fell thru the trees like rain
drowning the meadows with madness
while out of every imitation cloud
dropped myriad of wingless crowds
of nutless nagaski survivors
And lost teacups

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full of our ashes
floated by

So pledge allegiance to America . . One nation under God; indivisible; with liberty and justice . . . but is it truly justice for all?

Sometime during eternity
some guys show up
and one of them
who shows up real late
is a kind of carpenter
from some square-type place
like Galilee
and he starts wailing
and claiming he is hip
to who made heaven
and earth
and that the cat
who really laid on us
is his Dad

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And moreover
he adds
It's all writ down
on some scroll-type parchments
which some henchmen
leave lying around the Dead Sea somewheres
a long time ago
and which you won't even find
for a coupla thousand years or so
or at least for
nineteen hundred and fortyseven
of them
to be exact
and even then
nobody really believes them
or me
for that matter

You're hot
they tell him

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And they cool him

They stretch him on the Tree to cool
And everybody after that
is always making models
of this Tree
with Him hung up
and always crooning His name
and calling Him to come down
and sit in
on their combo
as if he the king cat
who's got to blow
or they can't quite make it

Only he don't come down from His Tree

Him just hang there
on His Tree
looking real Petered out
and real cool

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and also
according to a roundup
of late world news
from the usual unreliable sources
real dead

And yet why focus on foreign concepts such as liberty, beauty, justice, faith; when the average American's world is only slightly larger than his/her own dinner plate, gas tank, city park . . so why worry? Americans of all people should have every opportunity to be happy!

In Golden Gate Park that day
a man and his wife were coming along
thru the enormous meadow
which was the meadow of the world
He was wearing green suspenders
and carrying an old beat-up flute
in one hand
while his wife had a bunch of grapes
which she kept handing out
individually

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to various squirrels
as if each
were a little joke

And then the two of them come on
thru the enormous meadow
which was the meadow of the world
and then
at a very still spot where the trees dreamed
and seemed to have been waiting thru all time
for them
they sat down together on the grass
without looking at each other
and ate oranges
without looking at each other
and put the peels
in a basket which they seemed
to have brought for that purpose
without looking at each other

and then

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he took his shirt and undershirt off

but kept his hat on

sideways

and without saying anything

fell asleep under it

And his wife just sat there looking

at the birds which flew about

calling to each other

in the silly air

as if they were questioning existence

or trying to recall something forgotten

But then finally

she too lay down flat

and just lay there looking up

at nothing

yet fingering the old flute

which nobody played

and finally looking over

at him

without any particular expression

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except a certain awful look

of terrible depression

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lawrence Ferlinghetti
ISBN: 978-0811200417
Publisher: New Directions Publishing
Date(Month/Year): Oct 1974

AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier

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